

THE NEW GUARD

<< REWIND

It was hope against hope, when the Congress-led coalition went past the BJP-led NDA in the May general elections. Leaving behind a shell-shocked BJP, the Congress emerged as the single largest party, their efforts to reach the grassroots with the *aam aadmi* campaign, as against the BJP's lofty India Shining sloganeering, paying off. Sonia Gandhi pulled off a coup when she renounced the prime ministership, saying, "I am not attached to any particular post."



SIPRA DAS

DELUGE OF DOOM

What should I do—mourn the loss of my loved ones or worry about an uncertain future?" This dilemma of a victim of the devastating December 26 tsunami was shared by the whole world. The deadly waves, caused by an earthquake of 9.0 magnitude under the Indian Ocean, killed over 85,000 around the world and at least 10,000 people in India. Waves, as high as 100 feet, caused deaths as far as on the east coast of Africa. In India, the islands of Car Nicobar were virtually wiped off the map and Cuddalore and Nagapattinam, along the coast of Tamil Nadu, suffered the worst on the mainland. While relief operations began swiftly, the sheer geographical spread of the tragedy stretched all resources. Within 24 hours of the disaster, nearly 35,000 people had been provided shelter in 67 camps. But many still are homeless.

FIRST CUT

• India launched the \$20 million, 2-tonne EDUSAT from Sriharikota on September 20. This was the world's first dedicated educational satellite. It was also the heaviest satellite

that was ever launched by an Indian rocket.

• India made history when it won its first Test series on Pakistani soil. The Men in Blue defeated Pakistan 2-1.

